

Do parties respond? How electoral context influences party responsiveness



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ABSTRACT

How responsive are political parties to the issue priorities of voters? While there are numerous studies that examine policy position congruence between parties and voters or government responsiveness, we know little about the extent to which parties adjust their policy priorities to the issue concerns of voters. Following saliency and issue ownership theory, we argue that political parties listen to their voters by emphasizing policy issues in their election manifestos that have been prioritized by citizens. However, in line with second-order election theory, we expect that issue responsiveness varies with the electoral context. To test our theoretical expectations, we generated a novel dataset that combines data on issue attention of political parties from the Comparative Manifesto and the Euromanifesto projects with data on policy priorities of voters from the European Election Studies, the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems and various national election studies. We empirically test our theoretical claims based on a comprehensive analysis of 104 parties from 17 countries competing in 84 national and European elections from 1986 to 2011. Our findings have important implications for political representation in Europe.

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1. Introduction

Political parties are important intermediary organizations that link voters with political decision-making (Lawson, 1980; Dalton et al., 2011). As one of their key functions, parties aggregate and articulate voter preferences (Dalton and Wattenberg, 2000) and thus provide an important channel through which democratic decision-making is legitimized. It is, however, crucial for political representation that political parties are responsive to voter demands. Huber and Powell (1994) and Powell (2000) have argued that in addition to procedural representation, which is the proportionality of vote and seat share, substantive

representation is equally important in democracies. Substantive representation (Miller and Stokes, 1963) requires that there is congruence between the policy preferences of voters and the policy positions that political parties adopt. Considering the dynamic relationship of parties and voters, Stimson et al. (1995) developed the concept of dynamic representation to describe how a party shifts its policy positions in response to changes in public opinion. Ezrow et al. (2011) have recently tested and confirmed this relationship by analyzing the responsiveness of mainstream parties in Europe. We argue, however, that policy congruence is only one part of the story. In addition, it is also important that political parties listen to their voters with regard to the policy issues they emphasize in democratic societies. We thus argue that political parties respond to the policy priorities of voters, but that party responsiveness varies across electoral contexts. Following second-order election expectations (e.g. Reif and Schmitt, 1980), we

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posit that parties are more responsive to voters in national elections than in elections to the European Parliament.

The research agenda of many political parties' scholars in recent years has been to understand the nature of the relationship between voters and parties with regard to their policy positions. Adams et al. (2004), for example, have found that parties adjust their positions in response to changing public opinion. Looking at the context of the election, Adams et al. (2009) qualify this finding by showing that right-wing parties adjust their policy positions as a response to both changing global economic conditions and shifts in public opinion, whereas left-wing parties are less responsive to both factors. Ezrow and Hellwig (2011), however, show that as parties become further integrated into world markets, they become less responsive to preference shifts of the electorate. While these studies have considerably enhanced our knowledge of party responsiveness to voters, they have exclusively looked at preference congruence while neglecting the responsiveness in terms of issue priorities.

Another line of research focuses on the link between policy priorities of citizens and government policy (e.g. Wlezien, 1995; Stimson et al., 1995; Jones and Baumgartner, 2004; Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008; Jennings and John, 2009; Chaqués Bonafont and Palau, 2011; Bevan and Jennings, 2014). Two mechanisms have been identified that explain why governments respond to issue priorities of citizens: electoral turnover and anticipatory pressure (Stimson et al., 1995). Government responsiveness through electoral turnover occurs due to the choice of one government over another. If a government fails to enact policies that are supported by the electorate, it may be replaced by a government which is more in line with public preferences. Responsiveness due to anticipatory pressure occurs as governments adjust their policies to public preferences in the light of upcoming elections to maximize their re-election chances. In addition, scholars have shown amongst others that government responsiveness varies with institutional friction (Bevan and Jennings, 2014), with the timing of elections (Chaqués Bonafont and Palau, 2011), and with the levels of political contestation (Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008).

Both lines of research have made important contributions toward understanding the link between voters and their representatives; there is, however, an important gap in the literature which we address in this article. While party scholars have primarily been concerned with policy position shifts of political parties in response to changes of voter preferences, the second line of research has studied the responsiveness of governments to the policy priorities of citizens rather than looking at the responsiveness of political parties more generally. In this study, we thus extend this previous research by examining whether political parties listen to voters with regard to the attention they pay to different policy issues (see also Wagner and Meyer, 2014). Importantly, this article also builds on current research that focuses on how voters are influenced by the issues that parties emphasize and those in which they are perceived to have competences (e.g. van der Brug, 2004;

Bélanger and Meguid, 2008; Green and Hobolt, 2008; Green and Jennings, 2012; Reher, 2013).

Various scholars have offered insight into what determines the attention that parties pay to political issues. First, parties' policy priorities are based on the issues they own (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996) as well as the issues that other parties own. Recent research has demonstrated that parties cannot only emphasize their own issues, but must also respond to the issues of other parties in the system (see, e.g. Damore, 2004; Holian, 2004; Sigelman and Buell, 2004; Green and Hobolt, 2008; Spoon et al., 2013). Second, parties' priorities are placed on the agenda by issue entrepreneurs or by other parties in the system (e.g. Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010; Hobolt and De Vries, 2011). Third, they are affected by the political and economic context (Duverger, 1959; Inglehart, 1997).

In line with these previous findings, our central argument is that political parties not only respond to shifts in voter preferences, but that they also listen to voters when deciding which policy issues to emphasize in their election manifestos. Hence, we expect that there is a positive relationship between the attention that voters pay to a given policy issue and the attention that parties devote to this issue. However, following the insights of second-order election theory (Reif and Schmitt, 1980), we hypothesize that the issue responsiveness of parties is not constant across all elections, but that it varies with the electoral context. We thus argue that because of the second-order nature of European elections, parties pay less attention to the issue priorities of voters when deciding on which issues to primarily focus.

To understand the relationship between parties and voters and how it differs in first- and second-order elections, we examine parties' responsiveness to voters' issue priorities from 1986 to 2011 in 17 European countries. More specifically, we analyze the responsiveness of 104 parties across 13 issue areas in 79 national and five European elections. We measure party issue attention using data from the Comparative Manifestos Project (CMP) and the Euromanifestos Project (EMP). Issue priorities of voters are measured using data on the most important issue/problem that is obtained from the European Election Studies, the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, and various national election studies.

2. Party issue responsiveness in elections

In this section, we present our theoretical argument in detail. We begin by outlining our assumptions about party behavior from which we derive the argument that parties are responsive to the issue priorities of voters. Drawing on second-order election theory, we argue that issue responsiveness is not constant across all elections, but that it varies with the electoral context and the timing in the national electoral cycle.

2.1. Issue responsiveness of political parties

Parties are rational, goal-oriented and purposeful collective actors that aim to maximize the achievement of their preferences. Following the party behavior model set out by Riker (1962), we assume that parties are office-seeking actors. Parties seek to win elections for

instrumental reasons as they are primarily interested in obtaining control of political offices. Importantly, we make no assumptions about the underlying motivation for office-seeking behavior as political offices might be valued for different reasons (Strøm and Müller, 1999).

What strategy do political parties pursue in order to obtain control over political offices? Theories of party competition have largely been dominated by positional theories, such as the Downsian proximity model (Downs, 1957) or the directional model (Rabinowitz and Macdonald, 1989; Kedar, 2005). These theories suggest that parties seek to maximize the number of votes by adjusting their policy positions in response to the preference configuration of voters on certain policy issues. Changing policy positions may, however, be difficult to achieve as parties are committed to certain positions because of their ideology or their reputation (see, e.g. Robertson, 1976; Kollman et al., 1992). Building upon the saliency theory of party competition (Budge and Farlie, 1983), the issue ownership model (Petrocik, 1996), and acknowledging the issue interaction among parties (Damore, 2004; Holian, 2004; Sigelman and Buell, 2004; Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010; Hobolt and De Vries, 2011), we argue that an important strategy to win elections is to selectively emphasize political issues that are prioritized by voters. These theories predict that political parties compete with each other by emphasizing different policy issues. Parties, moreover, engage in selective issue ownership and focus on the issues on which they have an advantage. We thus posit that choosing which political issues to talk about in the first place is an important piece of the puzzle.

Political parties seek to mobilize voters by emphasizing political issues that are important to them.² Building on extant literature that has shown that voters' electoral choices are shaped by the issues that parties emphasize (e.g. van der Brug, 2004; Bélanger and Meguid, 2008; Green and Hobolt, 2008; Green and Jennings, 2012; Reher, 2013), we argue that voters not only distinguish between different parties based on their policy positions, but that it is also important to voters which parties devote attention to their preferred policy issues. Imagine a scenario in which a political issue is very important to a voter. For instance, imagine the voter is a strong supporter of same-sex marriage. Now imagine a party that is also in favor of same-sex marriage, but which pursues other policy priorities and largely neglects the issue of same-sex marriage. Even though the party has a position that is close to the ideal point of the voter, it is unlikely that the voter votes for that party as it does not spend any time and effort focusing on the issue or bringing it to the top of its political agenda. Hence, we expect that office-seeking political parties will be responsive to voters' issue priorities and systematically emphasize policy issues that are important to their electorate, which is our first hypothesis.

H1. *The higher the attention that voters pay to a given policy issue at t_{-1} , the higher the attention that parties pay to this issue at t_0 .*

2.2. The second-order nature of European Parliament elections

Are office-seeking political parties always responsive to issue priorities of voters or does issue responsiveness vary with the electoral context? Drawing on the second-order elections theory (Reif and Schmitt, 1980), we argue that political parties are more responsive to the policy priorities of voters in national elections than in elections to the European Parliament (EP).

Elections to the European Parliament play a very different role for office-seeking political parties than elections at the national level. While domestic elections, particularly in parliamentary systems, decide the allocation of political offices between parties, elections to the European Parliament do not lead to the distribution of any executive posts. Although the competences of the European Parliament have been considerably extended over the years, EP elections continue to only decide the composition of the Parliament without being connected to the distribution of executive office positions (for a further discussion, see Hix et al., 2007). As a result, there is not a great deal at stake for office-seeking political parties in European Parliament elections. Hence, political parties have little incentive to invest time and effort into adjusting their issue priorities to voter concerns.

What is more, political parties do not have to fear that a lack of issue responsiveness in European elections will affect their office-seeking objectives at the national level. The extensive literature on elections to the European Parliament has argued that EP elections primarily constitute so-called second-order elections (Reif and Schmitt, 1980). Voters have little knowledge and interest in European issues and hardly pay any attention to European Parliament elections. As a result, turnout in EP elections is considerably smaller than turnout in national elections. In addition, voters behave differently in these elections than they do in national elections. In EP elections, small parties perform much better than in domestic elections and governing parties are typically punished (Reif, 1984; van der Eijk and Franklin, 1996; Hix and Marsh, 2007, 2011). These effects are generally attributed to the low salience context of European elections. Hence, given the little attention that voters pay to European Parliament elections, political parties have little incentive to change their issue priorities in response to policy priorities of voters who may not care and do not pay attention to EP elections. Following the extant literature, we thus expect parties to be more responsive to voters in first-order national elections and less responsive to voters in second-order EP elections, which is our second hypothesis.

H2. *Parties will be less responsive to the issue priorities of citizens in elections to the European Parliament than in national elections.*

The literature on second-order elections has moreover demonstrated that the timing of the European election in the national election cycle affects the salience of the elections to

² Note, however, that building on the literature on issue avoidance and ambiguity, Rovny (2012), argues that parties take clear positions on issues in which they hold an extreme view and blur their positions on issues that are detrimental to them.

voters, their vote choice, and in turn, how governing parties fare in the election (e.g. Reif, 1984; Hix and Marsh, 2007). If EP elections take place close to national elections, political parties are subject to increased monitoring by their voters. As a result, office-seeking political parties will be generally more responsive to the issue priorities of voters in EP elections if they take place in proximity to national elections to avoid electoral punishment at the domestic level. Similar to the work of Reif (1984), Marsh (1998) and Hix and Marsh (2007) on voters' choices in EP elections, however, we expect a curvilinear relationship between the timing of the EP elections in the national election cycle and how responsive parties are to voters. We argue that the further away the EP election is from first-order national elections, parties have less incentive to respond to voters' issue priorities. Hence, we expect parties' responsiveness in EP elections to be u-shaped across the national electoral cycle. More specifically, the responsiveness of political parties in EP elections is relatively low if these take place in the middle of the national electoral cycle, but responsiveness increases the closer the proximity of an EP election is to the previous or the next national election. Our final hypothesis is thus:

H3. *The responsiveness of political parties in European Parliament elections increases as proximity to national elections (both the previous and the next election) increases.*

3. Data and methods

We now turn to a detailed discussion of how we empirically test our claims. We first discuss how we measure the dependent variable, party attention to policy issues, and how we selected the data. We then explain how we operationalized the explanatory and control variables.

3.1. Measuring party issue attention and data selection

To test our theory of party responsiveness, we examine how parties respond to the issue priorities of voters in 17 European countries.³ We obtain information about the attention that political parties pay to different policy issues from their manifestos which they draft for the election campaign. In both national elections and elections to the European Parliament, European political parties craft manifestos in which they highlight their policy priorities and express their positions on different policy issues. These statements allow parties to convey their issue preferences to voters. Among the decisions parties make in the manifesto-drafting process is whether to emphasize a certain issue by devoting a great deal of space to it, discuss an issue, but devote only a limited amount of space to it, or ignore the issue altogether by not mentioning it in the manifesto. While we recognize that not all factions within a party may agree on the party's issue priorities, we follow the extant literature (e.g. Adams et al., 2004, 2009; Ezrow et al., 2011) and assume

that the final manifesto is the outcome of negotiations among the different intra-party groups. With only a few exceptions, parties create two different manifestos for national and European elections which allows us to study their issue responsiveness in different electoral contexts.

We look at parties' responsiveness across 13 issue areas. These issue areas group together similar policy categories from the Comparative Manifesto (Klingemann et al., 2006; Volkens et al., 2012) and Euromanifesto (Schmitt et al., 2005) projects. Table 1 shows the policy categories that we included in each issue area. The environment issue area, for example, includes two policy categories – anti-growth economy (416) and environmental protection (501). Note that the issue areas do not reflect positions; in other words, they include both positive and negative mentions of the issue. Thus, the multiculturalism category includes both support and opposition to multiculturalism. We combine these issue dimensions as we are interested in measuring how salient an issue is for a party and not necessarily the position it has taken. Our dependent variable is thus the party's attention to an issue area in a specific election, whether national or European. This is measured by summing the percentage of the party's manifesto in each of the 13 issue areas. For instance, if 10% of the quasi-sentences that a manifesto contains are devoted to the multiculturalism category (either positive or negative mentions) while 20% are classified into the European integration category (either positive or negative), the attention that this party pays to multiculturalism is operationalized as 10% and the attention to European integration is coded as 20% in our dataset.

3.2. Measuring explanatory variables

Our main independent variable is the *issue priority of voters* measured as the most important issue/problem (MIP) in various public opinion surveys. We follow the approach of other scholars for measuring citizens' policy priorities (e.g. Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008; Jennings and John, 2009; Chaqués Bonafont and Palau, 2011). For voters' issue priorities in European elections, we use the MIP question in the European Election Studies beginning in 1989. We use this as our starting point, as the most important issue question was not asked in earlier European Election Studies or Eurobarometer surveys. At the national level, we use data from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems and from various additional national election studies.⁴ See the Appendix for a list of election studies used for the most important issue/problem data.

For some countries, there was no election study conducted (Bulgaria, Cyprus, Greece, Lithuania, Romania, and

³ The countries included in our analysis are Austria, the Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland, Portugal, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, and the United Kingdom. We do not include all 27 EU member states in our analysis as we did not have public opinion data on the most important problem/issue for these countries.

⁴ To be consistent across countries, we only use MIP data from national election studies and not from other polls or surveys. All of the questions we use are open-ended. We recognize that 'most important issue' and 'most important problem' are not necessarily the same question (see Wlezien, 2005; Jennings and Wlezien, 2011 for a more recent discussion of how there is little difference between the two questions) and that MIP questions do not always accurately capture the public's preferences (see Jennings and Wlezien, 2012). However, as these are the best cross-national questions available to gauge policy priorities of citizens, we use both most important issue and most important problem questions in order to have as much of a cross-national time series as possible (see Jennings and John, 2009, 844).

Table 1
CMP-emp issue areas.

CMP-emp policy categories	Issue area
703: Farmers	Agriculture
201: Freedom and human rights	Civil Rights
202: Democracy	
603: Traditional morality (positive)	
604: Traditional morality (negative)	
705: Underprivileged minority groups	
706: Non-economic demographic groups	
502: Culture	Culture
401: Free enterprise	Economy
402: Incentives	
403: Market regulation	
404: Economic planning	
408: Economic goals	
409: Keynesian demand management	
410: Productivity	
412: Controlled economy	
413: Nationalization	
414: Economic orthodoxy	
704: Middle class and professional groups	
506: Education expansion	Education
507: Education limitation	
416: Anti-growth economy (positive)	Environment
501: Environmental protection	
108: EC/EU (positive)	European integration
110: EC/EU (negative)	
203: Constitutionalism (positive)	Institutional and administrative reform
204: Constitutionalism (negative)	
301: Decentralization	
302: Centralization	
303: Government and administrative efficiency	
304: Political corruption	
305: Political authority	
101: Foreign and special relations (positive)	International politics
102: Foreign and special relations (negative)	
103: Anti-imperialism (positive)	
104: Military (positive)	
105: Military (negative)	
106: Peace (positive)	
107: Internationalism (positive)	
109: Internationalism (negative)	
406: Protectionism (positive)	
407: Protectionism (negative)	
605: Law and Order	Law and order
601: National way of life (positive)	Multiculturalism
602: National way of life (negative)	
607: Multiculturalism (positive)	
608: Multiculturalism (negative)	
503: Social justice	Social welfare
504: Welfare state expansion	
505: Welfare state limitation	
606: Social harmony	
411: Technology and infrastructure	Technology and infrastructure

Slovakia), while for others, the question was significantly different from the typical open-ended most important problem/issue question and thus answers would not be comparable. In Belgium, for example, voters were asked to identify five political objectives of the government that were most important to them. For these reasons, we only include 17 countries in our analysis. For some of these countries, however, an MIP question was not asked in every

parliamentary election survey, thus we only include the elections for which we have a comparable MIP question in our dataset.

We then matched each response with one of our 13 manifesto-based issue areas so that we could examine party responsiveness in each issue area. Thus, if a respondent said that taxation, employment, wages, or inflation was the most important issue in the election, these were put in the ‘economy’ category. We dropped the issues that voters mentioned for which there was no clear fit with our issue categories, such as mentions of specific parties or politicians, as well as those which could have been coded as several issue areas. Importantly, as there were generally very few voters who named an issue that did not fit into one of our categories, very few observations were lost by doing this.

We argue that political parties need time to respond to voters’ policy concerns. When voters change their issue priorities, political parties need time to process these changes and have to adjust their party manifestos accordingly. Drafting electoral manifestos takes a lot of time as there are many actors involved which have to coordinate, and most importantly, have to come to an agreement on the policy priorities and the positions that parties want to convey in their manifestos (see, e.g. Däubler, 2012). We thus use public opinion data from the previous election at t_{-1} to explain the attention that political parties pay to policy issues at t_0 . Depending on the timing of the election in the election cycle, the previous election could be a national or a European election.

To measure the *timing of the European election in the national election cycle*, we count the number of months between the last national election and the European election. Following the extant literature on the timing of the EP election in the national election cycle (e.g. Reif, 1984; Marsh, 1998; Hix and Marsh, 2007), we posit that there is a curvilinear relationship between the timing of the EP elections in the national election cycle and how responsive parties are to voters. We thus include the base variable which counts the number of months between elections and a squared variable.

3.3. Operationalization of control variables

We also include several control variables in our models. First, we take into consideration both party and party system level variables as we argue that both influence how responsive parties are to voters in national and European elections. At the party level, we include three variables – party size, whether a party is a niche or mainstream party, and governing party status. Following the extant literature (e.g. Adams et al., 2006; Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2010; Ezrow et al., 2011), we argue that larger parties, mainstream parties, and governing parties will be more responsive to voters. We operationalize *party size* as the vote share of a party in the national election. Thus, we consider the party’s vote share in the last national election as a measure of its size. We use Meguid’s (2005) definition of *niche party* and code green, regional, and far right parties as such. To determine whether a party was in *government*, we look at the composition of the national government

Table 2
Examining party responsiveness in EP and national elections.^a

DV: party issue attention t_0	Model 1		Model 2	
	Coefficient	Std. error	Coefficient	Std. error
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.076***	0.008	0.139***	0.009
EP election	−1.684***	0.245	−0.641***	0.239
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * EP election			−0.187***	0.015
Months since last national election	0.001	0.016	0.002	0.016
Months since last national election (squared)	−0.000	0.000	−0.000	0.000
Party size	0.401	0.805	0.353	0.778
Government status	0.082	0.152	0.063	0.148
Niche party	0.078	0.289	0.076	0.282
Average party system issue salience t_{-1}	0.167***	0.035	0.197***	0.034
EU policy	−0.052***	0.013	−0.050***	0.013
Pro/Anti EU position	0.017	0.025	0.016	0.024
Membership duration	−0.007	0.005	−0.006	0.005
Post-Maastricht	−0.037	0.249	0.006	0.242
Party issue attention t_{-1}	0.263***	0.033	0.263***	0.033
Constant	4.398***	0.385	3.719***	0.367
N	6006		6006	
R ²	0.22		0.25	

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

^a Results are from OLS regressions with clustered robust standard errors.

following the previous national election. The data on party size were obtained from the CMP dataset and the government participation data comes from the ParlGov dataset (Döring and Manow, 2012). At the party system level, we include a variable that measures *average issue salience*, for the party system in a given election. We posit that parties' issue emphasis is not only influenced by voters' issue priorities, but also by those of other parties. Similar to the voter issue attention variable, we used the party system's average issue attention from the previous election.

Next, as we are interested in party responsiveness in European elections to European issues, we incorporate two party level variables focused on the European issue. First, we include a dichotomous variable for the *European issue category* in our dataset. Second, we include a variable that measures the party's *position on European integration*. We use Klingemann et al.'s (2006) method of subtracting negative mentions of European integration from positive mentions to measure the ideological position of political parties on the pro/anti European integration dimension. In European elections, we expect all parties to be more responsive on the European issue and parties that are more Europhile to be even more responsive to voters.

Finally, we include two country level variables in our analysis. First, we use a variable that measures the *length of time in years a country has been a member of the EU*. We expect membership duration to have a positive effect on responsiveness as both parties and voters have had more time to adapt to the European environment. As voters will pay increasing attention to party behavior at the European level, political parties have more incentive to respond to their policy priorities. Second, we also include a dichotomous variable for the *Maastricht Treaty*. Following the entry

into force of the Maastricht Treaty in 1993 and the introduction of the co-decision procedure, the powers of the European Union have been extended and the EP has become more influential in European policy-making. We thus argue that parties should be more responsive to voters in their Euromanifestos post-Maastricht as there is more at stake in European elections.⁵ See the Appendix for the descriptive statistics for all the variables included in our analysis.

4. Data analysis

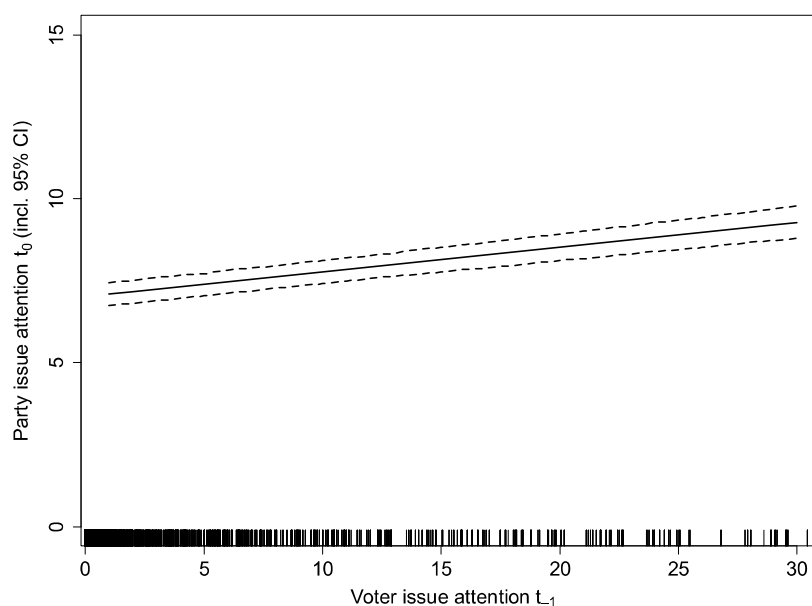
To test our theoretical expectations on the basis of the collected data, the special structure of the data has to be taken into account. Our observations are clustered into 104 parties as well as into 13 issue areas so that the observations are not completely independent as assumed by ordinary regression. In order to take into account the clustering of the data, we estimate ordinary least squares regression with clustered robust standard errors. As our observations are clustered both into political parties and issue areas, we created a cluster variable that takes this twofold clustering into account so that one cluster corresponds to a political party and a specific issue area. We do this as a party's emphasis of one issue area may not be independent of its emphasis of another issue area. In addition to the clustering, the dataset is also characterized by a time component as we analyze succeeding elections.⁶ To control for potential autocorrelation induced by the time series structure of the data, we include the lagged dependent variable (Beck and Katz, 1995, 1996; Beck, 2001).

To test the robustness of the results, we also estimated two further model specifications. First, we estimated the OLS model using the concurrent MIP variable to test whether parties and voters pay attention to different policy issues during the same election. Second, rather than looking at the levels of issue attention, we estimated an OLS model explaining the shift in issue attention of parties between t_{-1} and t_0 with the shift in issue attention of voters from t_{-2} to t_{-1} . Both model specifications yield the same substantial findings and we therefore only report the results of the base model explaining party issue attention at t_0 with voter issue attention at t_{-1} . (See Tables A2 and A3 in the Appendix for the results of the alternative specifications).

Table 2 presents the results of OLS regression analysis. Model 1 indicates that political parties indeed listen to their voters, which is the expectation proposed in hypothesis 1. The issue priorities of citizens at time point t_{-1} have a statistically significant effect on the policy issues that parties emphasize in their manifestos at t_0 . The higher the salience of a policy issue is to voters at time point t_{-1} , the

⁵ We also ran the analysis with dichotomous variables that represented additional key time points in the development of the European Union (the Single European Act, Nice, Amsterdam, and Lisbon Treaties) as we would expect to find increasing responsiveness following these treaties as well. However, none of the variables were statistically significant.

⁶ We have also estimated an OLS model that includes country fixed effects. The results are similar and none of the country dummies has a statistically significant effect.



Note. The figure is based on model 1 reported in table 2. The markers at the bottom of the plot illustrate the distribution of voter issue attention.

Fig. 1. Issue responsiveness of political parties.

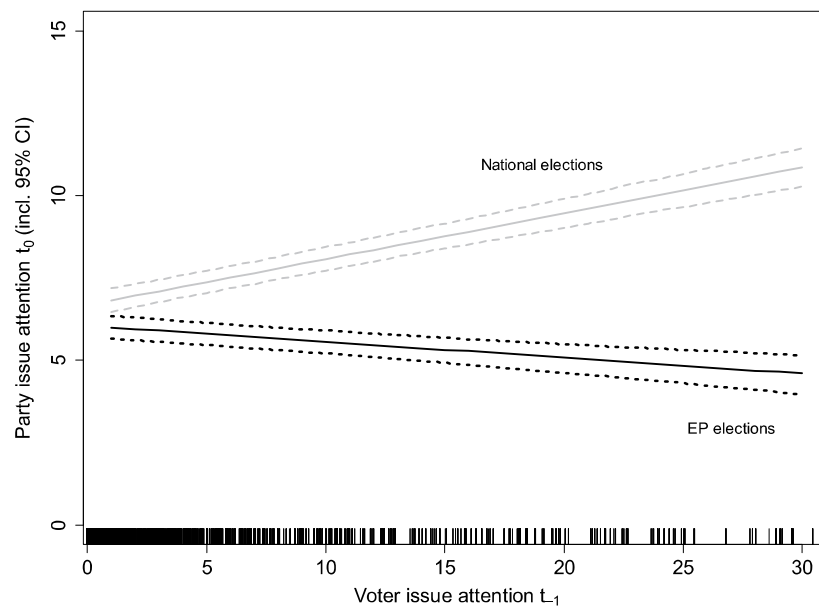
more attention parties pay to this issue at t_0 . More specifically, if the number of citizens that consider an issue a policy priority increases by one percentage point, party attention to this issue on average rises by 0.08 percentage points. Hence, political parties are not only responsive with regard to the policy position they adopt on the left-right or the pro/anti European integration dimension as scholars have shown in previous research (e.g. Adams et al., 2004; Mattila and Raunio, 2012), but parties also listen to their voters when it comes to choosing which policy issues should be prioritized in the political debate.

In order to further illustrate the issue responsiveness of political parties, we simulated predicted values to show to what extent parties listen to their voters (King et al., 2000). Fig. 1 displays the predicted values for party attention on a given policy issue at time point t_0 on the y-axis and the attention that voters pay to this policy issue at time point t_{-1} while all other variables are held at their mean (continuous variables) or median (categorical variables) values. The solid line indicates the point estimates and the dashed lines represent the 95% confidence interval. At the bottom of the plot, the markers indicate the distribution of issue attention among voters. Overall, the figure demonstrates that party emphasis of a given policy issue at t_0 steadily increases as a reaction to voter attention to this issue at t_{-1} . When voter issue attention increases by one standard deviation, party issue attention at t_0 increases by about 1.2%. The analysis thus provides empirical support for hypothesis 1 – parties are indeed responsive to the issue priorities of their voters.

Following the extant literature, we recognize that there may be a reciprocal relationship between voters and

parties, that is that parties are not only responding to voters' preferences, but that voters might also respond to parties' issue emphasis (e.g. Adams et al., 2004, 2009; Bélanger and Meguid, 2008). In order to test whether voters also respond to political parties, we performed two checks. First, we conducted a Granger causality test to determine whether party issue attention at t_{-1} can predict voter issue attention at t_0 . The test indicates that voter issue attention indeed Granger causes party issue attention while we do not find any empirical evidence for the reversed relationship. In addition, we have also estimated a reversed multivariate regression model with voter attention as the dependent variable and the lagged party issue attention as the independent variable to test the potential reciprocal relationship between voters and political parties. In line with the results of the Granger causality test, voter attention at t_{-1} does not have a statistically significant effect on party issue attention at t_0 . Hence, both checks support the claim that political parties respond to the issue priorities of voters while not providing any evidence for the reversed relationship.

In hypothesis 2, we argued that issue responsiveness is not constant across different types of elections; political parties listen more to policy priorities of voters in national elections than in elections to the European Parliament. To empirically test whether party responsiveness truly varies with the electoral context, we have included an interaction term between voter attention at t_{-1} and a dummy variable distinguishing between national and European elections in model 2. The OLS regression analysis shows that there is indeed a systematic difference between national and EP elections. The interaction term is statistically significant



Note. The figure is based on model 2 reported in table 2. The markers at the bottom of the plot illustrate the distribution of voter issue attention.

Fig. 2. Issue responsiveness in national and EP elections.

and negative which indicates that parties are less responsive to policy priorities of voters in elections to the European Parliament than in national elections.⁷

To further illustrate the size of the interaction effect, we have simulated predicted values for issue responsiveness in national and EP elections which are presented in Fig. 2 (see Brambor et al., 2006). The markers at the bottom of the plot illustrate the distribution of voter issue attention. The figure clearly shows that there is an important difference between national and EP elections. While there is a positive relationship between voter attention to a given policy issue at t_{-1} and the attention a party pays to this issue at t_0 in national elections, there is a slightly negative relationship between voters' policy priorities and the issues emphasized by political parties in their Euromanifestos. More specifically, when voter issue attention increases by one standard deviation, party issue attention at t_0 decreases in EP elections by 0.75% whereas it increases in national elections by 2.18%. Hence, although political parties take the policy concerns of voters seriously in national elections by emphasizing these issues in their election manifestos, they largely ignore the issue priorities of citizens in elections to the European Parliament. This follows the expectations in the literature on the nature of second-order elections (Reif and Schmitt, 1980).

⁷ In order to test the robustness of this finding, we have estimated two additional models in which we separately analyze the responsiveness of political parties to voters in national and in European Parliament elections. We find that political parties respond to voter priorities in the previous national election when drafting their national election manifesto while there is no systematic effect of voter issue attention in the previous EP election on issue attention in parties' manifestos in the succeeding EP election.

With regard to the control variables, models 1 and 2 show that parties not only listen to their voters in determining their issue priorities, but they are also responsive to other parties in the party system as the significant coefficients for average issue salience demonstrate. The models also indicate that political parties generally pay less attention to European policy in comparison to other issues.

Is the lack of issue responsiveness in EP elections a general phenomenon or does it vary across the national electoral cycle and across party type? In order to empirically test whether the absence of party responsiveness in EP elections is a general phenomenon, we have estimated an additional OLS regression model which includes three-way interaction terms for all the control variables included in the analysis with voter issue attention at t_{-1} and the dummy variable distinguishing between national and EP elections. The results are reported in Table 3.

The OLS regression reported in model 3 points to several significant relationships. First, the proximity to national elections has a systematic effect on issue responsiveness as the interaction terms including the number of months and the squared number of months since the last election have a statistically significant effect, as posited in hypothesis 3. The results thus suggest a curvilinear relationship, which follows the findings of Reif (1984), Marsh (1998) and Hix and Marsh (2007). Parties are more responsive to voters if European Parliament elections take place in close proximity to national elections (both past and future elections) while party responsiveness is significantly lower if EP elections take place in the middle of the national electoral cycle. However, the size of the interaction effect is extremely small and thus the effect of the electoral cycle on party responsiveness should not be over emphasized.

Table 3
Explaining party responsiveness in EP elections.^a

DV: party issue attention t_0	Model 3	
	Coefficient	Std. error
<i>Constitutive terms</i>		
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.204***	0.047
EP election	1.052	0.923
Months since last national election	−0.007	0.023
Months since last national election (squared)	0.000	0.000
Party size	0.361	1.186
Government status	0.238	0.238
Niche party	0.449	0.423
Average party system issue salience t_{-1}	0.313***	0.039
EU policy	0.032	0.020
Pro/Anti EU position	0.027	0.041
Membership duration	−0.005	0.008
Post-Maastricht	−0.062	0.330
Party issue attention t_{-1}	0.260***	0.033
<i>Two-way interactions</i>		
EP election × Voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.157**	0.066
Months since last national election × voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.002	0.002
Months since last national election (sq) × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.000	0.000
Party size × voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.019	0.069
Government status × Voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.021	0.018
Niche party × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.054*	0.031
Average party system issue salience t_{-1} × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.078***	0.002
EU policy × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.013	0.010
Pro/Anti EU position × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.004	0.003
Membership duration × voter issue attention t_{-1}	−0.000	0.000
Post-Maastricht × voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.025	0.027
Months since last national election × EP election	0.021	0.036
Months since last national election (sq) × EP election	−0.000	0.000
Party size × EP election	−1.023	2.015
Government status × EP election	−0.252	0.400
Niche party × EP election	−0.294	0.662
Average party system issue salience t_{-1} × EP election	−0.125***	0.043
EU policy × EP election	−0.162***	0.032
Pro/Anti EU position × EP election	−0.003	0.048
Membership duration × EP election	−0.006	0.013
Post-Maastricht × EP election	−0.405	0.699
<i>Three-way interactions</i>		
Months since last national election × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	−0.007**	0.003
Months since last national election (sq) × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.000**	0.000
Party size × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.099	0.109
Government status × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.032	0.028
Niche party × Voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.022	0.044
Average party system issue salience t_{-1} × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.001	0.002
EU policy × Voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.006	0.014
Pro/Anti EU position × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.003	0.003
Membership duration × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	0.001*	0.001
Post-Maastricht × voter issue attention t_{-1} × EP election	−0.047	0.043
Constant	2.851***	0.528
<i>N</i>		6006
<i>R</i> ²		0.027

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

^a Results are from an OLS regression with clustered robust standard errors.

Turning now to the control variables, we do not find a systematic effect of governmental status. Government parties are on average neither more nor less responsive to voters in EP elections than opposition parties. Party type (size and mainstream or niche status) and the position toward the European Union also do not have a significant effect on issue attention. The relationship between party type and responsiveness thus warrants continued investigation in future research. Indeed, the literature is somewhat divided on how party type affects this core aspect of

representative democracy (e.g. Adams et al., 2006; Ezrow et al., 2011; van de Wardt, 2012). Model 3 furthermore indicates that parties become more responsive to voters in EP elections the longer their country has been a member of the European Union. This finding suggests that issue responsiveness of parties increases in EP elections as parties and voters have become used to the European arena. However, we did not find any difference with regard to the responsiveness of parties on EU issues compared to the responsiveness on other issues. A party's EU position also did not

affect responsiveness. Finally, model 3 indicates that party responsiveness in EP elections has not increased after Maastricht despite the extended powers of the European Parliament.

5. Conclusion

Do political parties listen to their voters when deciding which policy issues to prioritize? While representation, congruence and responsiveness studies typically assess the link between parties and voters with regard to the policy position a party adopts or the responsiveness of governments to the issue priorities of voters (e.g. [Stimson et al., 1995](#); [Powell, 2000](#); [Adams et al., 2004, 2009](#); [Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008](#); [Chaqués Bonafont and Palau, 2011](#); [Ezrow et al., 2011](#); [Mattila and Raunio, 2012](#)), we know little about the extent to which political parties adjust the policy priorities to issue concerns of citizens. Political representation is not only about the positions of voters and parties toward certain policy issues or the extent to which governments are responsive to issue concerns of citizens, it is also about the attention to political issues in the first place. It is important for political representation that parties pay attention to the issues that are important to voters.

In this study, we have shown that political parties do listen to the issue priorities of voters when selecting which issues to emphasize in their election manifestos. The attention that voters pay to a particular policy issue at time point t_{-1} has a positive effect on the attention that parties pay to this issue at time point t_0 . However, we have demonstrated that the issue responsiveness of political parties is not constant across all elections, but that it varies with the electoral context. Following the second-order theory of elections (e.g. [Reif and Schmitt, 1980](#)), we have found that political parties listen much more to their voters in national elections than in elections to the EP.

Our findings have important implications for political representation in Europe. Although we have demonstrated that parties are intermediary organizations that link the policy priorities of citizens to the political realm, as [Lawson \(1980\)](#) described, we have also shown that the quality of political representation varies with the electoral context. While political parties particularly emphasize policy issues that are important to voters in national elections, they largely ignore voter priorities in elections to the European Parliament. This finding raises important normative concerns with regard to political representation in the European Union, which has been severely criticized for a lack of democratic legitimacy (see [Føllesdal and Hix, 2006](#) for further discussion of this debate). Even though the European Parliament has been considerably strengthened over the years in order to improve the accountability of the EU institutions to European citizens, our results show that political parties, which are major players in the Parliament ([Hix et al., 2007](#)), largely ignore the issue priorities of citizens thereby weakening the democratic link between voters and the European Parliament.

In conclusion, this study constitutes an important first step in understanding the relationship of parties and voters as it relates to issue responsiveness. However, there are many questions that remain unanswered. In future research, we hope to open the political party box to further comprehend parties' issue prioritization in both national and European elections and how and why it varies. First, we still contend that party type (whether determined by size, niche versus mainstream ([Meguid, 2005](#)), party family, or governing versus opposition status) should influence responsiveness. Second, we would like to unpack the relationship between parties and the electorate as a whole as compared to parties and their own voters, much as [Adams et al. \(2006\)](#) and [Ezrow et al. \(2011\)](#) have done looking at policy congruence. Are parties more likely to respond to their own voters or those of the electorate? And, furthermore, are certain types of parties more likely to respond to the issue priorities of their own voters or those of the electorate more generally? Third, we would like to explore the interaction of policy position and issue salience – are parties more likely to respond to voters when they share their policy preferences? What is more, do parties strategically de-emphasize or emphasize policy issues on which the electorate is divided? Finally, future research should examine *how* issue salience for both parties and voters changes during the course of the election campaign by exploring such factors as the media and exogenous events.

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Appendix

Table A1
Descriptive statistics

	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min.	Max.
Party issue attention	6743	6.644	6.775	0.000	72.382
Voter issue attention	6743	5.995	13.311	0.000	89.800
Months since last national election	6743	24.599	15.285	0.000	56.667
Months since last national election (squared)	6743	838.716	765.895	0.000	3211.111
Party size	6743	0.170	0.136	0.000	0.506
Government status	6743	0.363	0.481	0.000	1.000
Niche party	6743	0.194	0.396	0.000	1.000
Average party system issue salience	6447	6.842	5.448	0.000	31.076
EU policy	6743	1.324	4.572	0.000	18.000
Pro/Anti EU position	6743	2.474	5.541	−44.444	25.698
Membership duration	6743	25.203	18.168	−4.000	58.000
Post-Maastricht	6743	0.895	0.306	0.000	1.000
EP election	6743	0.516	0.500	0.000	1.000

Table A2Examining party issue attention in EP and national elections (concurrent voter and party attention)^a

DV: party issue attention at t_0	Model 1		Model 2	
	Coefficient	Std. error	Coefficient	Std. error
Voter issue attention at t_0	0.046***	0.008	0.155***	0.019
EP election	−1.878***	0.283	−0.843***	0.275
Voter issue attention at t_0 * EP election			−0.172***	0.020
Months since last national election	−0.003	0.019	−0.003	0.019
Months since last national election (squared)	−0.000	0.000	−0.000	0.000
Party size	0.295	0.865	0.334	0.866
Government status	0.018	0.171	0.049	0.169
Niche party	0.033	0.297	0.034	0.294
Average party system issue salience t_{-1}	0.164***	0.040	0.200***	0.039
EU policy	−0.070***	0.014	−0.064***	0.013
Pro/Anti EU position	0.016	0.027	0.017	0.027
Membership duration	−0.005	0.006	−0.008	0.006
Post-Maastricht	0.032	0.331	−0.007	0.337
Party issue attention at t_{-1}	0.273***	0.038	0.273***	0.038
Constant	4.602***	0.511	3.922***	0.500
<i>N</i>	4767		4767	
<i>R</i> ²	0.21		0.24	

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.^a Results are from OLS regressions with clustered robust standard errors.**Table A3**Examining party issue attention shift in EP and national elections^a

DV: party issue attention shift from t_{-1} to t_0	Model 1		Model 2	
	Coefficient	Std. error	Coefficient	Std. error
Voter issue attention shift from t_{-2} to t_{-1}	0.016**	0.006	0.024***	0.007
EP election	−0.950***	0.226	−0.950***	0.225
Voter issue attention shift from t_{-2} to t_{-1} * EP election			−0.025**	0.012
Months since last national election	0.012	0.022	0.009	0.022
Months since last national election (squared)	−0.000	0.000	−0.000	0.000
Party size	−0.241	0.606	−0.278	0.608
Government status	−0.072	0.156	−0.068	0.156
Niche party	0.087	0.189	0.089	0.186
Average party system issue salience t_{-1}	−0.220***	0.024	−0.223***	0.024
EU policy	−0.014	0.009	−0.014	0.009
Pro/Anti EU position	0.028	0.022	0.028	0.022
Membership duration	−0.007	0.004	−0.006	0.004
Post-Maastricht	−0.013	0.415	−0.028	0.416
Party issue attention shift from t_{-2} to t_{-1}	−0.607	0.021***	−0.606***	0.021
Constant	2.031***	0.517	2.061***	0.519
<i>N</i>	4044		4044	
<i>R</i> ²	0.48		0.48	

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.^a Results are from OLS regressions with clustered robust standard errors.**National and European election studies**

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